

cursives are written with lower case letters, often run together, and usually with spacing between words; the material used was parchment or paper. The uncial script was exclusively used until the ninth century, when the first cursive MSS appear. By the eleventh century the cursive script had taken over.

The international list of extant (known) NT MSS is maintained by the Institute for New Testament Textual Research (INTF) in Münster, Germany. It is called the *Kurzgefasste Liste*.¹ As of February, 2018, that list contained 133 papyri, 282 uncials (majuscules) and about 2,850 numbered cursives (minuscules).

The dating of MSS is a slippery business, vulnerable to presupposition, bias and ‘party line’. The reader should understand that the dates that have been assigned to the individual MSS may be little more than rough guesses; so much so that they are usually given as a century. When a MS has a specific date, the copyist wrote the date when he finished.

I made a rough tabulation of the papyri by century (taking the later date when there was an option);² they range from the II to the VIII: II—4, III—49, IV—31, V—14, VI—16, VII—16, VIII—3. Of those 133 papyri, 35 have less than five verses (they are mere fragments);³ 76 have between six and twenty verses (still fragments); 13 more have less than two chapters; only 9 of them are of significant size. For some 40 chapters throughout the NT there is no papyrus witness. Only Luke, John, Acts, Hebrews, 1 & 2 Peter and Jude have a papyrus witness for a full chapter. Only one papyrus has a complete book: P⁷² contains 1 & 2 Peter and Jude. The importance attached to the papyri will depend on one’s presuppositions.

I made a rough tabulation of the uncials by century (taking the later date when there was an option); they range from the III to the XI: III—2, IV—18, V—50, VI—65, VII—36, VIII—27, IX—62, X—20, XI—2. Of these 282 uncials, 182 have less than one chapter (most of them have only a few verses; some even less); another 37 have less than a whole book; only 63 have a complete book or more. The importance attached to the uncials will depend on one’s presuppositions.

¹ Kurt Aland, ed., *Kurzgefasste Liste der Griechischen Handschriften des Neuen Testaments* (Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, 1994).

² This paragraph, and the next, are simply based on the *Liste* (whether I agree, or not).

³ In my opinion, the only contribution of a fragment is to establish that any variant it contains existed when it was written, if it was not created by the copyist. A fragment earlier than AD 100 establishes that the book existed at that time.